

KEY WORKS: Twelve Etudes (piano solo), Op. 8, 1894; Piano Sonata No. 4 in F-sharp major, Op. 30, 1903; Poem of Ecstasy (orchestra), Op. 54, 1908; Five Preludes (piano solo), Op. 47, 1914

Josef Suk

1874–1935, CZECH

Violinist and composer Josef Suk was introduced to music by his father, a village teacher and choirmaster. He entered the Prague Conservatory at the age of 11 and had written several of his most successful works by age 20. He became the favorite pupil of Antonín Dvořák, and married Dvořák's daughter Otilie in 1898. The happiness of this period of his life is reflected in his incidental music for the play *Radúz a Mahulena* (1898). The deaths of both Dvořák and Otilie in 1904–1905 inspired the grief-stricken symphony *Asrael*, widely considered his finest work. In his later music, including the impressive symphonic poem *Ripening*, he adopted a more Modernist style, exploring polytonality. He played as a violinist with the prestigious Czech Quartet for 40 years. Much of his energy later in life was devoted to teaching composition at the Prague Conservatory.
